American Political Divides and Great Debates

[84–309] | Fall 2026

Prof. Jonathan Cervas

Updated: November 13, 2026

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CMU Academic Calendar

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The most up-to-date version of this **syllabus can be found here**.

Course Relevance: DC: Perspectives on Justice and Injustice
Learning Resources: All resources will be provided via Canvas
Prerequisites: NONE

August

S	M	T	W	T	F	S
						1
2	3	4	5	6	7	8
9	10	11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20	21	22
23	24	25	26	27	28	29
30	31					

September

S	M	T	W	T	F	S
		1	2	3	4	5
6	7	8	9	10	11	12
13	14	15	16	17	18	19
20	21	22	23	24	25	26
27	28	29	30			

October

S	M	T	W	T	F	S
				1	2	3
4	5	6	7	8	9	10
11	12	13	14	15	16	17
18	19	20	21	22	23	24
25	26	27	28	29	30	31

November

S	M	T	W	T	F	S
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
8	9	10	11	12	13	14
15	16	17	18	19	20	21
22	23	24	25	26	27	28
29	30					

December

S	M	T	W	T	F	S
		1	2	3	4	5
6	7	8	9	10	11	12
13	14	15	16	17	18	19
20	21	22	23	24	25	26
27	28	29	30	31		

in person remote no class

Why are Americans so divided — and is the premise even true? We spend a month on what political science actually knows, then the semester is yours: student teams pick the topics, assign the readings, and run the room.

01 Assessment

The course grade will be a weighted average of the following components:

Assignment	Percent of Final Grade
Attendance	**25%**
Discussion Board (before each class)	**15%**
Student Led Topics	**9%**
Surveys (3: intake, midterm, evaluation)	**2%**
Book Review (Slides + Presentation)	**12%**
Op-Ed Project (Draft + Review + Final)	**20%**
Group Policy Brief	**17%**

02 Due Dates

Assignment	Due Date
Discussion board post	9:00 a.m., each class day
Surveys (3)	August 26, October 7, final week
Op-ed topic, on the board	September 15 (subject), 17 (replies)
Op-ed, first draft	September 21
Op-ed peer review	September 25
Op-ed final draft	September 28
Book Review (slides)	November 23
Policy brief draft	November 30
Group Project	December 1/3
Group Project reflection	December 4
Policy brief final	December 10

03 The Essentials

- **Before every class**: one short discussion-board post, due **9:00 a.m.**, in Canvas. Two more fall in the no-class week of **September 15**, where the class settles op-ed subjects.
- **Attendance is 25%.** The first three absences cost almost nothing; four to six is where a semester goes wrong.

- **Late work** costs one point per hour, but never drops below 50%. The **op-ed rough draft (September 21)** is the one deadline with no exceptions: it loses 10% immediately, then 1% per hour, down to the same 50% floor, because two classmates are waiting on it.
- **Devices stay in bags.** Non-class use of a laptop or phone means being marked absent for that session.
- **Surveys** and their screenshot receipts run through **Canvas, under Assignments**.

04 The Full Syllabus

Everything else — the week-by-week schedule with all readings, assignment details, and every policy — lives in the full syllabus:

https://jcervas.github.io/teaching/2026-2027/class-cmu-2026-84-309/readme.html